

COLLEGE OF BUSINESS EDUCATION

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Question 40

“Why should research objectives begin with verbs such as to examine, to assess, to determine, or to identify?”

Introduction

Research methodology is defined as the systematic, theoretical framework used to solve a research problem. It is the overall strategy and philosophy that guides how a researcher designs their study, selects their tools, and validates their findings. Research methodology forms the backbone of any academic inquiry. Among the most fundamental components of a sound research proposal is the formulation of well-structured research objectives.

Research Objectives

In research methodology, **Research objectives** are the specific, clear, and concise statements that declare exactly what a study aims to achieve. They break down the overarching research problem into actionable, measurable steps.

The Core Structure of a Research Objective

A properly written research objective always follows a specific **three-part formula**:

1. **The Action Verb:** Must be an active, operational verb (e.g., *To identify, To examine, To determine, To evaluate*).
2. **The Target Variables:** The specific concepts, behaviors, or elements you are measuring (e.g., *smartphone addiction, job performance, consumer preference*).
3. **The Target Population:** The group or context being studied (e.g., *first-year undergraduate students, SME employees, retail shoppers*)

Why Research Objectives Begin with Action Verbs

In research methodology, objectives must always begin with active, operational verbs (such as *to examine, to assess, to determine, or to identify*) for three core reasons:

1. They Ensure Measurability (Operationalization)

A fundamental rule of research is that your goals must be measurable. Passive verbs like *"to study"* or *"to learn about"* describe internal mental processes that cannot be physically measured. Action verbs describe observable actions. By the end of your study, you must be able to prove you achieved your objectives. You can visually prove that you *"identified"* a factor or *"determined"* a statistic; you cannot prove that you *"understood"* it.

2. They Dictate the Research Design

The specific active verb you choose informs the reader of your methodological approach and scope:

- **To Identify:** Signals a descriptive or exploratory study (e.g., finding the main causes of employee turnover).
- **To Examine / To Assess:** Signals an analytical approach, usually evaluating relationships between variables or the effectiveness of a system.
- **To Determine:** Signals a causal or conclusive approach, often requiring quantitative data to find a definitive statistical result or impact.

3. They Guide Data Collection and Analysis

Active verbs establish a direct roadmap for your methodology. If your objective is *"to compare online and offline sales,"* your data collection tools (surveys or financial records) and your data analysis methods (such as a t-test) are instantly defined. Active verbs eliminate ambiguity, ensuring that your data collection directly answers your research questions.

Real-World Examples

Example Topic: Student Academic Performance

- **Using "To Identify" (Exploratory / Descriptive Design)**
 - *Objective:* **To identify** the primary distractions causing procrastination among undergraduate students.
 - *What it tells the reader:* The study will likely use a survey or focus group to create a list of common distractions (e.g., social media, part-time jobs).
- **Using "To Assess" (Analytical / Relational Design)**
 - *Objective:* **To assess** the relationship between daily smartphone usage hours and GPA scores among undergraduate students.
 - *What it tells the reader:* The study is quantitative. It will collect specific numbers (hours vs. grades) and use correlation statistics to see how they impact each other.
- **Using "To Determine" (Causal / Conclusive Design)**
 - *Objective:* **To determine** if a mandatory time-management workshop significantly improves final exam scores for first-year students.
 - *What it tells the reader:* This is likely an experimental study. The researcher will compare a group that took the workshop against a group that did not, using a statistical test (like a t-test) to find a definitive cause-and-effect result.

Conclusion

Research objectives must begin with action verbs for six key reasons: measurability, clarity, methodological alignment, scope definition, achievability, and academic convention. Action verbs like *to examine*, *to assess*, and *to determine* are not interchangeable each signals a different level of inquiry, type of data, and analytical method. In quantitative research such as the Tanzania SME digital banking study, the right verb directly determines which SPSS tools are used. Ultimately, using action verbs is not just a style rule it is a core methodological requirement for any rigorous and credible research study.